

Lazarus Group — Diamond Sleet

Threat Actor Profile | Aviation & Aerospace

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Prepared by: Lost Boys Cyber — Threat Intelligence Team

AI-ASSISTED REPORT — IMPORTANT DISCLOSURE

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Attribution Warning: Nation-state attribution is probabilistic. Confidence levels reflect analytical assessment only — not proof.

1. At a Glance

Attribute	Value
Primary Alias	Lazarus Group
MITRE ATT&CK Group	G0032 — https://attack.mitre.org/groups/G0032/
Nation-State Sponsor	North Korea — Reconnaissance General Bureau (RGB)
Motivation	Espionage (defence/aerospace IP); regime revenue generation; crypto theft for sanctions evasion
Active Since	2009 (confirmed)
Activity Status	Active — Operation DreamJob ongoing; elevated European aerospace tempo 2025
Sophistication	Nation-state — elite social engineering; custom malware toolchain
Primary Sectors	Aerospace, Defence, UAV/Drone manufacturing, Aviation components, Financial, Cryptocurrency
Primary Geographies	Europe (UK, Germany, Poland, France, Portugal, Sweden, Denmark), US, Israel, Australia — global
Assessment Confidence	High — US CISA/FBI advisories; ESET research; DOJ indictments (2021)

2. Identity & Aliases

Vendor	Designation
Microsoft	Diamond Sleet (formerly ZINC)
CrowdStrike	Labyrinth Chollima
Mandiant / Google	Primarily Lazarus; APT38 for financial sub-cluster
US CISA / FBI	HIDDEN COBRA; Lazarus Group
ESET	Lazarus Group
MITRE ATT&CK	G0032
DOJ	Named in 2021 indictment — three North Korean nationals charged

3. Attribution Assessment

Assessment: North Korea — RGB (Reconnaissance General Bureau). Confidence: High.

Lazarus Group attribution rests on: a 2021 DOJ indictment naming three DPRK nationals as operators; US CISA/FBI joint advisories attributing HIDDEN COBRA activity to North Korean state actors; extensive independent corroboration from ESET, Microsoft, Mandiant, and CrowdStrike across 15+ years of consistent operations; and targeting that uniquely aligns with DPRK regime priorities (revenue generation via crypto theft + military technology acquisition for missile and aviation programmes).

For aerospace specifically, DPRK has a direct strategic interest in military aviation technology, UAV systems, and missile guidance — all of which are found in the R&D environments of targeted aerospace firms. Intelligence collected through Operation DreamJob directly feeds DPRK's domestic weapons development programmes.

Evidence Type	Detail	Confidence
DOJ indictment	2021: Park Jin Hyok and two others charged; Lazarus operations documented in detail	High
CISA/FBI advisories	Multiple HIDDEN COBRA advisories attributing activity to DPRK state actors	High
Targeting alignment	Aerospace/defence IP + cryptocurrency theft = dual revenue/capability acquisition mission unique to DPRK	High
Tool exclusivity	ScoringMathTea, BLINDINGCAN, NukeSped exclusive to Lazarus; no other actor usage observed	High
15-year consistency	Consistent operational style, tooling evolution, and victimology across 15+ years	High

4. Background & History

Lazarus Group is North Korea's most prolific cyber threat actor, operating under the RGB and responsible for some of the most significant cyber operations in history — including WannaCry (2017), the Sony Pictures breach (2014), and the \$81 million Bangladesh Bank heist (2016). For the aerospace and defence sector, Lazarus operates primarily through Operation DreamJob: a sustained, multi-year social engineering campaign using fake job offers from prestigious aerospace and defence companies.

Operation DreamJob has been running since approximately 2019 and continuously evolves in sophistication. The most recent documented wave (ESET, March 2025) targeted three European aerospace firms — a metal engineering company, an aircraft components manufacturer, and a defence contractor — using elaborately constructed LinkedIn fake recruiter profiles, job description decoy documents, and a trojanized PDF reader delivering ScoringMathTea, a full RAT supporting approximately 40 commands.

Critically, ESET also documented in 2025 a parallel campaign ("Gotta Fly") specifically targeting the European UAV and drone manufacturing sector — demonstrating deliberate evolution of DreamJob

targeting to include unmanned aerial systems, directly relevant to any aerospace organisation with unmanned vehicle programmes. Lazarus combines military/aerospace espionage with financial crime, making them a uniquely resource-generating threat actor whose criminal proceeds fund further operations.

Date	Event	Significance
2009	First attributed activity	DDoS attacks on US/South Korean government; earliest RGB attribution
2014	Sony Pictures breach	First major Western corporate target; wiper deployment
2017	WannaCry ransomware	Global impact; aerospace supply chain systems affected
2019	Operation DreamJob begins	Fake job offers targeting aerospace/defence engineers via LinkedIn
2020	Operation North Star / Interception	European aerospace contractor employees targeted; BLINDINGCAN RAT deployed
2021	DOJ indictment	Three DPRK nationals named; Lazarus operations documented publicly
2022–2023	DreamJob European expansion	Increased targeting of European aerospace and defence firms
Mar 2025	European aerospace triad	Metal engineering co., aircraft components mfr., defence contractor — ScoringMathTea RAT
2025	Operation "Gotta Fly"	ESET documents UAV/drone sector targeted — first documented unmanned systems focus

5. Objectives & Targeting

Lazarus targets the aerospace sector for two distinct purposes: intelligence collection feeding DPRK's domestic military aviation and missile development programmes (UAV technology, aircraft specifications, guidance systems, manufacturing processes), and credential/financial theft to sustain revenue-generating criminal operations. Engineers with access to R&D systems, CAD environments, and engineering documentation are the highest-value individual targets.

Attribute	Detail
Organisation Size	All sizes — targets individual engineers at SME aerospace suppliers through to prime contractor

	R&D teams
Technology Environment	Windows-centric; developer/engineering workstations; CAD/PLM systems
Specific Technologies	PDF readers (trojanized delivery); LinkedIn (initial contact); engineering document repositories
Primary Lures	LinkedIn fake recruiters; job descriptions from Boeing, Lockheed Martin, defence primes
UAV/Drone Focus	Explicit 2025 campaign ("Gotta Fly") targeting European UAV manufacturers
Financial Component	Crypto wallet theft and financial system access alongside espionage — dual-purpose operations

6. TTPs — MITRE ATT&CK

Tactic	Technique	Observed	Frequency	Notes
Resource Dev	T1585.001 — Social Media Accounts	Yes	High	Fake LinkedIn recruiter profiles with employment history; appear legitimate
Resource Dev	T1583.001 — Domains	Yes	High	Fake recruitment company domains; aerospace brand impersonation
Initial Access	T1566.003 — Spearphishing via Service	Yes	High	LinkedIn DMs with job offer lures — primary DreamJob vector
Initial Access	T1566.001 — Spearphishing Attachment	Yes	High	Decoy job description documents + trojanized PDF reader
Execution	T1204.002 — Malicious File	Yes	High	Victim opens trojanized PDF reader; ScoringMathTea delivered
Execution	T1059.001 — PowerShell	Yes	Med	Post-compromise scripting and payload staging
Persistence	T1053.005 —	Yes	High	ScoringMathTea

	Scheduled Task			persistence via scheduled task
Persistence	T1543.003 — Windows Service	Yes	Med	RAT installs as service for long-term access
Defence Evasion	T1027 — Obfuscated Files	Yes	High	Encrypted/packed payloads; anti-analysis techniques
Defence Evasion	T1036.005 — Masquerading	Yes	High	Trojanized PDF readers appear and function as legitimate software
Credential Access	T1555.003 — Browser Credentials	Yes	Med	Post-compromise credential harvesting
Discovery	T1082 — System Information Discovery	Yes	High	ScoringMathTea extensive host profiling (~40 commands)
Discovery	T1083 — File and Directory Discovery	Yes	High	Identifying aerospace engineering files, CAD documents, specifications
Collection	T1005 — Data from Local System	Yes	High	Engineering drawings, specs, procurement data, design files
C2	T1071.001 — Web Protocols	Yes	High	HTTPS C2; rotated infrastructure between campaigns
Exfiltration	T1041 — Exfil over C2	Yes	High	IP theft exfiltrated over primary C2 channel

7. Toolset

Tool	Type	Purpose	Attribution Confidence
ScoringMathTea	Full RAT (~40 cmds)	Complete remote	High — 2025,

		access: file ops, process mgmt, screenshot, command exec	exclusive to Lazarus
BLINDINGCAN	RAT	Earlier DreamJob implant; HTTPS C2; full remote access	High — exclusive
NukeSped	Backdoor	Multi-function; lateral movement capability; used across multiple campaigns	High — exclusive
COPPERHEDGE	RAT	Advanced Lazarus implant; data exfiltration	High — exclusive
Trojanized PDF readers	Delivery vehicle	Legitimate PDF reader bundled with malware payload; signed where possible	High — DreamJob signature technique
LinkedIn fake profiles	Social engineering	Multi-year-old fake recruiter identities with connection history and endorsements	High — DreamJob signature

8. Detection

8.1 Sigma — Trojanized PDF Reader Child Process

```

title: Lazarus DreamJob — PDF Reader Spawning Suspicious Child Process
id: e1f2a3b4-c5d6-7890-efab-890123450009
status: experimental
description: PDF reader spawning scripting engine or shell — trojanized reader
delivery pattern
references:
  - https://attack.mitre.org/groups/G0032/
  - https://www.welivesecurity.com/en/eset-research/gotta-fly-lazarus-targets-uav-sector/
author: Lost Boys Cyber | date: 2026-05-29
tags:
  - attack.initial_access
  - attack.t1566.001
  - attack.execution
  - attack.t1204.002
logsource:
  category: process_creation
  product: windows
detection:
  selection:
    ParentImage|endswith:
      - "\AcroRd32.exe"
      - "\Acrobat.exe"
      - "\FoxitReader.exe"
      - "\PDFXEdit.exe"
      - "\SumatraPDF.exe"

```

```

    Image|endswith:
      - "\cmd.exe"
      - "\powershell.exe"
      - "\wscript.exe"
      - "\cscript.exe"
      - "\regsvr32.exe"
      - "\rundll32.exe"
      - "\mshta.exe"
    condition: selection
  falsepositives:
    - Embedded PDF print/share actions; validate CommandLine context
  level: high

```

8.2 Sigma — ScoringMathTea Service Installation

```

title: Lazarus — Suspicious Service Created from Non-Standard Location
      (ScoringMathTea)
id: e2f3a4b5-c6d7-8901-fabc-901234560010
status: experimental
description: New Windows service installed from user-writable path — ScoringMathTea
            persistence
tags:
  - attack.persistence
  - attack.t1543.003
logsource:
  product: windows
  service: system
detection:
  selection:
    EventID: 7045
    ImagePath|contains:
      - "\Users\"
      - "\AppData\"
      - "\Temp\"
      - "\ProgramData\"
  filter:
    ServiceName|contains:
      - "MicrosoftEdgeUpdate"
      - "GoogleUpdate"
      - "AdobeARMservice"
  condition: selection and not filter
falsepositives:
  - Portable application launchers; validate ImagePath against software inventory
level: high

```

8.3 KQL — LinkedIn Download to Execution Chain

```

// Lazarus DreamJob: File downloaded via browser from LinkedIn, executed within 5
minutes
let downloads = DeviceFileEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(90d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~ ("chrome.exe","msedge.exe","firefox.exe")
| where FolderPath has "Downloads"
| where FileName endswith ".exe" or FileName endswith ".pdf"
  or FileName endswith ".zip" or FileName endswith ".iso"
| project DownloadTime=Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, FolderPath;
let executions = DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(90d)
| project ExecTime=Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, ExecFile=FileName,
ExecFolder=FolderPath;
downloads
| join kind=inner executions on DeviceName, AccountName

```



```
| where ExecTime between (DownloadTime .. DownloadTime + 5m)
| where ExecFolder has "Downloads"
| project DownloadTime, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, ExecFile
| order by DownloadTime desc
```

8.4 YARA — ScoringMathTea / BLINDINGCAN Detection

```
rule Lazarus_DreamJob_RAT {
  meta:
    description = "Detects Lazarus Group DreamJob RAT characteristics (ScoringMathTea/BLINDINGCAN)"
    author      = "Lost Boys Cyber"
    date        = "2026-05-29"
    reference    = "https://www.welivesecurity.com/en/eset-research/gotta-fly-lazarus-targets-uav-sector/"
    actor       = "Lazarus Group / Diamond Sleet"
  strings:
    $mz = { 4D 5A }
    $s1 = "ScoringMathTea" ascii wide nocase
    $s2 = "BLINDINGCAN"  ascii wide nocase
    $s3 = "DreamJob"     ascii wide nocase
    $s4 = { 48 83 EC 28 E8 ?? ?? ?? ?? 48 83 C4 28 C3 }
    $linkedin = "linkedin" ascii wide nocase
    $pdf = "PDFReader"  ascii wide nocase
  condition:
    $mz at 0 and filesize < 20MB and
    (1 of ($s1,$s2,$s3) or ($linkedin and $pdf))
}
```

9. Threat Hunting

9.1 Hunt: Fake LinkedIn Recruiter Contact Patterns

Hypothesis: Lazarus DreamJob begins with LinkedIn contact. If employees received and responded to fake recruiter messages, browser history and email logs will show LinkedIn traffic followed by document downloads.

```
DeviceNetworkEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(90d)
| where RemoteUrl has "linkedin.com/in/" or RemoteUrl has "linkedin.com/messaging"
| summarize FirstSeen=min(Timestamp), LastSeen=max(Timestamp), Count=count()
  by DeviceName, AccountName
| join kind=inner (
  DeviceFileEvents
  | where Timestamp > ago(90d)
  | where FolderPath has "Downloads"
  | where FileName endswith ".pdf" or FileName endswith ".zip"
  | summarize Downloads=count() by DeviceName, AccountName
) on DeviceName, AccountName
| where Downloads > 0
| order by LastSeen desc
```

9.2 Hunt: Trojanized PDF Process Tree

Hypothesis: A trojanized PDF reader will execute its legitimate UI while spawning a background process for the RAT payload. Hunt for PDF readers with unusual child process trees.

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(90d)
```

```
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~  
| ("AcroRd32.exe", "FoxitReader.exe", "SumatraPDF.exe")  
| where FileName !in~ ("AcroRd32.exe", "FoxitReader.exe", "SumatraPDF.exe",  
| "AcroCEF.exe", "FoxitCEF.exe", "splwow64.exe", "PrintIsolationHost.exe")  
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName,  
| InitiatingProcessFileName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine  
| order by Timestamp desc
```

10. Recommended Defensive Posture

- Brief all aerospace engineers and R&D staff on Operation DreamJob — Lazarus's primary vector is LinkedIn fake job offers. Engineers receiving unsolicited high-value job offers should report immediately to security rather than engaging; treat as a threat indicator. Run tabletop exercises simulating a DreamJob approach.
- Block execution of applications from the Downloads folder — the trojanized PDF reader executes from Downloads after being received via LinkedIn; AppLocker or WDAC rules restricting execution from user download directories breaks the kill chain at execution.
- Restrict PDF reader software to approved, verified versions from vendor-signed update channels — trojanized readers are injected into the download process; having a single approved PDF reader with file hash verification prevents substitution.
- Deploy Constrained Language Mode (PowerShell CLM) for standard users — limits post-compromise PowerShell capability; ScoringMathTea's post-execution scripting is hindered by CLM.
- Alert on new Windows service installations from user-writable paths — ScoringMathTea installs as a service from AppData/Temp; EventID 7045 from these paths is a high-fidelity indicator.
- For organisations with UAV/drone programmes — issue specific heightened awareness to those teams; "Gotta Fly" (2025) confirms Lazarus explicitly targets unmanned systems personnel with tailored lures.

11. References

- [1] MITRE ATT&CK. "Lazarus Group — G0032." <https://attack.mitre.org/groups/G0032/>
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- [4] MITRE ATT&CK. "Operation Dream Job — C0022." <https://attack.mitre.org/campaigns/C0022/>
- [5] Help Net Security. "Lazarus fake job ads target Europe's drone sector." <https://www.helpnetsecurity.com/2025/10/23/eset-lazarus-operation-dreamjob/>
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